Ian Thomas White

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Overview

I am an academically trained linguist with substantial tech-industry experience. I have training in all linguistic subfields, with a focus on formal language theory, and I've leveraged my linguistics training at ML/AI companies. I'm a rigorous problem-solver across both quantitative (Haskell, Python, SQL) and qualitative (annotation, ontology, writing) domains.

Experience

Linguistics Trainer and QA Specialist, Human Data @ SpaceXAI *08.2024 – 08.2026*

- Annotated textual and visual/audio LLM outputs for adherence to phonological, syntactical, and semantic norms.
- Conducted model evaluation and QA for Python and SQL outputs.
- Wrote novel guidance and QA rubrics in Markdown, JSON, and Excel.
- Collaborated with engineers to ensure labeling guidelines accorded with machine learning principles and goals.
- Trained new tutors and developed algorithmic processes to improve tutor workflow and inter-annotator agreement.

Linguistics Instructor @ UCLA *09.2022 – 12.2023*

- Taught weekly seminars covering major linguistic subfields: phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics.
- Developed unique teaching materials and technical documentation using LaTeX and Haskell.
- Evaluated student performance and conducted regular one-on-one meetings with students.

Computational Linguist @ App Orchid *06.2021 – 09.2022*

- Designed syntactic-tree-based regexes to match complex, embedded legal phrases in an LLM pipeline.
- Labeled and taxonomized linguistic regularities in legal corpora for POS, NER, and dependency/constituency parsing.
- Researched string parsing techniques to optimize regex search algorithms.
- Integrated regexes into the LLM pipeline using Python, SQL, and Git and wrote accompanying technical documentation.
- Communicated regularly with engineers, clients, and other stakeholders to ensure optimal ML outcomes.

Literature Instructor @ University of Minnesota *09.2016 – 05.2020*

- Designed and implemented syllabi for key departmental courses on literary theory and practice.
- Wrote from scratch unique teaching materials on grammar and rhetoric.
- Evaluated student performance and conducted regular one-on-one meetings with students.

Library Associate @ Burke Library, Columbia University *09.2014 – 05.2016*

- Organized and cataloged library collections using Library of Congress classification.

Brain-Trainer @ LearningRx *05.2013 – 05.2014*

- Guided students of all ages through targeted cognitive training tasks and exercises.

Developmental Trainee @ Fraser *05.2013 – 05.2014*

- Assisted in teaching and developmental support for pre-school-age children with autism.

Editorial Intern @ Publishing Genius *05.2011 – 08.2011*

- Assisted publication and manuscript production for an independent small press in Baltimore.

Education

PhD (Incomplete), Linguistics @ UCLA *2020 – 2023*

- Research: Permutation Power in Minimalist Grammars and Combinatory Categorial Grammars
  Advisors: Dylan Bumford, Tim Hunter
- Took graduate courses in all linguistic subfields, as well as in algorithms and formal language theory.
- Applied research toward NLP/NLU applications using Python and Haskell.

MA, Linguistics @ University of Minnesota *2016 – 2020*

- Thesis: *The Argument Structure of Deverbal Nouns*
  Advisor: Jean-Philippe Marcotte
- Took graduate courses in all linguistic subfields: phonology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics, and computational linguistics.
- Completed corpora analysis projects using Python, NLTK, and Google Colab.

MA, Comparative Literature (Major), Greek (Minor) @ University of Minnesota *2016 – 2020*

- Thesis: *Discrete Infinity and Ring Structure in Penelope's Weaving Trick*
  Advisor: Christophe Wall-Romana
- Took graduate courses in literary theory, French-language poetry, and Greek-language literature.
- Used APA, MLA, and Chicago manuals of style to write research papers.

MA, Church History @ Union Theological Seminary *2014 – 2016*

- Thesis: *Just Imitations: The Literary and Comedic Qualities of the Apophthegmata Patrum*
  Advisor: John Anthony McGuckin
- Graduate study in church history, historical theology, and biblical languages.

BA, Writing Seminars @ Johns Hopkins University *2008 – 2011*

- Thesis: *Modern Mimesis: Alt-lit and Autofiction*

Presentations

Society for Classical Studies *2022*

- *Penelope's Endless Weaving and Ring Structure*

Awards & Fellowships

UCLA

- Graduate Summer Research Fellowship
- Summer Mentored Research Fellowship

University of Minnesota

- SSRC DPD Summer Fellowship
- CSCL Summer Research Fellowship
- CSCL Summer Grant
- 21st-Century Summer Language Fellowship

Union Theological Seminary

- Wyn Wright Prize for Biblical Languages

Johns Hopkins University

- The Robert R. Arellano Writing Award

Academic Service

University of Minnesota

- Member, CSCL Undergraduate Curriculum Committee

Skills

Programming: Git · Haskell · JSON · LaTeX · Markdown · MS 365 · NLTK · Notion · Python · PyTorch · Prompt Engineering · R · SQL

Linguistics: Computational · Formal Grammar · Lexical Semantics · Morphology · NLP · Philosophy of Mind · Phonology · Pragmatics · Syntax

Languages: English · French · Greek (Ancient, Koine) · Latin (Classical)

Competencies: Communication · Data Analysis & Annotation · Ontology Design · Research · Statistics · Taxonomy · Technical Writing